

Innovation Versus Invention



Maulik Jasubhai Publisher

WHY IS IT that technology products' life cycles are measured only in months? Why are some of their amazing features almost impossible to use?

Let's consider cell phones. Ever tried to use the acclaimed Web browsing feature from a cell phone? Or tried to plug it in to your notebook? Or ever counted how many clicks and sub-commands it takes to access the calendar function on your cell phone? Tried using it to make a 'conference call'? You do know that this feature exists, don't you?

Let's talk about cameras. I am sure many of you use multi-million pixel cameras. Once you are back from your vacation, how do you sort the pictures? How do you actually know what the picture contains given that all of them have cryptic numbers as file names? Tried to arrange them and make an album out of them? Or if you are using a much-vaunted camera phone, should it not be easier to download these pictures directly to a wire-free device that can make prints for you?

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Printing should be the easiest task. After all, how difficult can it be to print address labels in fabulous 300-dpi colour at 10 pages per minute? But wait. If you want to print directly on envelopes using Microsoft Outlook's contacts list, you cannot do it unless you first create a mail-merge document—a task about as easy and enjoyable as changing the spark plugs on your car every time you want to start it.

The lesson is that while hardware and software technology companies are far more sophisticated today than they were a decade ago, they have still left users more confused. They have been so busy 'Inventing' that they have not paid enough attention to 'Innovation'.

Innovation is the process of applying ingenious ideas to great inventions so that they become usable by normal people like us. For example when Tim Berners Lee 'invented' the Internet, it was largely useless to most of us till innovators like Marc Andreessen of Netscape, Jerry Yang of Yahoo! and dozens of others created applications that opened doors to this brand new world. It was the 'Innovative' adaptation of a simple hard drive technology that brought us the iPod.

So let's hope that this coming decade is one where Innovation finally overtakes Invention!

A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read 'Maulik Jasubhai'.